

Dependent Case, θ -Agreement, and Null Expletives

Joseph Sabbagh
Dept. of Linguistics & TESOL
UT Arlington

sabbagh@uta.edu

Abstract. This paper offers an analysis of case based on the *Dependent Case* approach developed by Marantz (1991) and as executed in much of the recent literature. I also present analysis of agreement in Tagalog, arguing against the *Case-agreement* hypothesis proposed by Rackowski (2002), and in favor of an analysis in which agreement targets θ -features, as developed in work by Reinhart (2016) and related work. The θ -agreement analysis I propose, in conjunct with the analysis of case, greatly simplified earlier approaches such as Rackowski's which, as I demonstrate, are difficult to formalize within the strictures of contemporary theories of Agree. The analysis presented gives way to an analysis of eventive existential constructions in Tagalog, which lead me to propose the existence of a null expletive pronoun that is projected in the syntax, roughly along the lines proposed by Collins (2024) for the implicit argument of short passives in English. (This is a preliminary draft as of August 2, 2025. Changes, corrections, etc. are soon to come. Comments welcome.)

1 Introduction

In the Minimalist framework, the operation Agree has played a central role in the description and analysis of a variety of phenomenon. Perhaps its most significant role involves the constructions of representations in which the core elements of a syntactic structure (e.g., heads and phrases) contain features that are pertinent to the morphological description of a language. In other words, Agree provides the relevant features to syntactic elements that then function as the input to things like realization rules, which map syntactic features to phonological content. Thus, the operation of Agree has been central to the analysis of the case and agreement systems found throughout the world's languages. Much research has been dedicated in recent years to the investigation of this operation – not only in terms of its scope (what all phenomenon involve the operation) but also its limits and restrictions.

Within the context of this research, one topic (among others) has received a great deal of attention recently: Case. As proposed by Chomsky (2000, 2001), Case assignment/valuation could be folded in to the operation Agree, thus departing from the GB-era theory of Case which assumed Case-assignment by syntactic heads to phrases under the local structural relation of government (see Bobaljik and Wurmbrand 2008 for an overview). More recently, the role of Agree in Case has been questioned, as an alternative view of Case/case, known as the *Dependent Case Approach* (DC-approach) has emerged (Marantz 1991, McFadden 2004) that essentially eliminates the notion of Case as a licensing mechanism for DPs in the syntax proper. As Agree is an operation of the syntax proper (the 'narrow syntax'), this means that Agree is not responsible for the licensing, assignment, or valuing of Case to nominal expressions in the syntax.¹ If approaches to case like the DC-approach are adopted, this has implications for other facets of Agree – in particular – for the role of Agree in explicating agreement systems across languages. When Chomsky first proposed Agree, he focussed on the relationship between case and agreement: Certain syntactic heads (e.g., Tense/Infl) value Case on DPs, and – DPs reciprocally value ϕ -features on these heads. On many versions of the DP-approach, case is a purely morphological phenomena, and not relevant to the syntactic computation. If agreement is tied to case, then – according to some versions of the DC-approach – agreement might also be taken from the syntax and relegated to the component of grammar that interfaces with PF (see, e.g. Bobaljik 2008). Since these potential implications are far-reaching, the work reported on here will mainly let them sit in the background. This paper has two main goals, however, that are relevant to these broader topics. First and foremost, I present an analysis of case in Tagalog that is exclusively based on a DC-approach to case. Thus, I eschew previous and even current approaches which maintain a "licensing" approach, according to which DPs have unvalued Case-features that must be valued and 'checked' via Agree by the end of the syntactic derivation. Moving case out of the syntactic derivation has implications for other aspects of Tagalog morpho-syntax, in particular – for analyses of the contrasting verbal morphology that is iconic of

¹For work that more broadly argues for the DC-approach, see Marantz 1991, McFadden 2004, Baker & Viranakova 200x, etc. Note that I use case (lower case c to refer to morphological case; and Case (capital c) when referring to *Abstract*. Where the term is interchangeable, I refer to [C]ase/[c]ase.

Tagalog and many other Western Austronesian languages. Descriptively speaking, Tagalog exhibits what might generally be referred to as a (Western) Austronesian Alignment System (henceforth, an WAAS), which is illustrated by examples like (1a-c).²

- (1) a. N-agbigay si Juan ng bolsa kay Maria.
 AT.PERF.give UNM DEP dress DAT
 ‘Juan gave a dress to Maria.’
 b. Binigay-Ø ni Juan ang bolsa kay Maria.
 PERF.gave-UT DEP UNM dress DAT
 c. Binigy-an ni Juan ng bolsa si Maria
 PERF.give-CT DEP DEP dress UNM

The key aspect of note for this WAAS is that the verb varies in accordance with the selection of a subject, which may correspond to any core or peripheral argument of the verb, and in some cases – even non-arguments. While described in terms of voice by some linguists, there is some consensus that the morphology of the verb instantiates some kind of agreement. Among researches who adopt this view, the central question (and dispute) is what features are the target of this agreement. While agreement in many linguistic systems clearly exhibit agreement for ϕ -features, such features are demonstrably not relevant for Tagalog. Two hypotheses remain: (i) agreement targets θ -features; or (ii) agreement targets Case-features. In this work, I put forward a proposal that agreement targets θ -features (Ramos 1973, De Guzman 1978, Carrier-Duncan 1983, and Kroeger 1993). Although this idea was once rather well-accepted, it has lost support in favor of the *Case-agreement* hypothesis in the wake of work by Rackowski (Rackowski 2002, Rackowski & Richards 2005, see also Pearson 2005). In this paper, I show that Case-agreement, in so far as its viewed as implemented through the operation of Agree, introduces several complications to the grammar of Agree that the alternative θ -agreement hypothesis does not. In short, the Case-agreement hypothesis ends up maintaining that Agree requires a probe to assign a value to a Case-feature, but also to obtain a value for a Case-feature of its own. This, I show, creates an undesirable complexity that should be eliminated if possible, and I argue that it is possible if agreement is for θ -features instead. The θ -agreement hypothesis has not been entertained in recent work, owing – I suspect – to the absence of a formal feature-oriented theory of θ -roles. The approach I develop in this paper draws inspiration from work by Tanya Reinhart developed over a series of works (Reinhart 2002, 2016) which puts forward explicit feature-based approach to θ -roles as part of a larger framework referred to as the “ θ -System”.

After presenting my approach to case and agreement for Tagalog, I discuss a potentially problematic case for my approach involving what I will call the *eventive existential*

²Because part of this work is attempt to argue that verbal morphology targets θ -eatures rather than Case-features, I have glossed the verbs following a somewhat traditional scheme. AT refers to ACTOR TOPIC morphology (for when the external argument is SUBJECT*); UT = UNDERGOER TOPIC is the form of the verb when a Patient/Theme is SUBJECT*, and CT = CONVENANCE TOPIC is the form of a verb when a more peripheral argument is SUBJECT*. In the main text, I refer to UT and CT as NON-ACTOR TOPIC.

construction, exemplified by an example like (2).

- (2) Magkaka-roon ng isang rebisyon ng librong iyan.
CONT.EXISTS-there DEP one.LK revision DEP book.LK this
'There will be a revision of this book.'
(English 1568, cited in Sabbagh 2009:679)

According to the analysis I present, the sole argument of the existential predicate *magkaka-roon* here should exhibit an unmarked case (*ang*) rather than the a marked, dependent case (*ng*). As I will discuss, an indeitical or near identical problem to this one arises in Greek, Icelandic, and Lithuanian. I therefore propose following work by authors such as Wood (2017) a solution to this problem based on the proposal that the grammar contains null expletives that may serve as case competitors for the purposes of determining dependent case. If correct, this works adds to the recent proposal by Collins (Collins 2024) that UG allows for null DPs (qua implicit arguments) to be projected in the syntax (see also Moltmann 2006, Landau 2010, and Rizzi 1986:512).

The remainder of this paper is structured as follows: Section 2 introduces and discusses Case/case in Tagalog generally, as well as analyses of Case-licensing and distribution involving Agree. This section also puts forward the relatively uncontroversial view that agreement involves an Agree relationship between the inflectional head of the clause, Tense (aka Infl) and a DP referred to as the SUBJECT*. Section 3 presents, then argues against the proposal that agreement targets Case-features. Section 4 outlines a DC-approach to case in Tagalog, and a theory (inspired by Reinhart's θ -System) for Tagalog agreement whereby T seeks values for unvalued θ -features. Section 5 is devoted to the eventive existential construction in Tagalog and related constructions in other languages, and argues for the presence of a null (implicit) argument in their structure. Section 6 concludes.

2 Case and Case Agreement

Our discussion opens with an analysis of Case assignment and the hypothesis of Case agreement in Tagalog, both of which are formulated from the perspective of early Minimalist theories of the syntactic operation of Agree (Chomsky 2000, 2001). According to that theory, Agree is an operation that involves two elements – a Probe (P) (typically, a functional head, H) and a Goal (G) (typically a phrase such as DP). Agree is not an obligatory operation of the Grammar, per se, but is 'triggered' to apply to eliminate features from the syntactic representation that are uninterpretable at the semantic interface. For a syntactic representation to be 'legible' at the semantic interface, Agree must apply. The conditions under which Agree applies are summarized in (3), from Deal (to appear).

- (3) Structural Description: Agree holds between a probe and a goal iff all of the following conditions hold.
- The probe bears uF: features that are uninterpretable and unvalued.
 - The probe c-commands the goal.
 - The uF of the probe matches with iF on the goal.
 - The goal is active: it also has uninterpretable features (uF')
 - The goal is the closest element to the probe meeting the conditions above.

As a result of Agree, F's value is copied to the probe from the goal (=valuation), and the uninterpretable features of the goal are given values according to the nature of the probe (=goal flagging). With valuation having taken place, uninterpretable features are deleted.

Broadly speaking, Rackowski adopts this Agree model in her analysis of Case assignment and agreement in Tagalog. However, as we will see, her system requires significant departures from the basic strictures outlined in (3), resulting in a fairly complex system with added stipulations that calls into question whether a simpler picture might be conceivable. Let us begin with Rackowski's analysis of Case assignment. (Note, I am using 'C' to refer to the concept of abstract Case, rather than morphological case (with 'c').) Rackowski's analysis here is pretty standard. Adopting the general view that Tagalog is a nominative-accusative language (cf. Aldridge, who analyses the language as ergative-absolutive), she proposes that a DP is assigned or valued Accusative ([Acc]) Case by v (in particular, v_{trans}) when it enters an Agree relationship with it, and that Nominative ([Nom]) case is assigned to a DP by T upon Agree. This analysis is summarized/schematized in (4) (note, shading is used to indicate a value for a previously unvalued feature).

- (4) T[C:Nom] ... [_{VP} DP[C:____] v[C:Acc] [_{VP} V DP[C:____]]
- Agree(v, DP):**
 $[_{VP} DP[____] v[C:Acc] [_{VP} V DP[C: \text{Acc}]]$
 - Merge T, Agree(T, DP):**
 $T[C:Nom] ... [_{VP} DP[C: \text{Nom}] v[C:Acc] [_{VP} V DP[C: \text{Acc}]]$

Supposing for present purposes that only the probe in the Agree relation needs to be unvalued (pace Chomsky 2001:5-6), we can see that the distribution of Case plays out under Rackowski's analysis in a fairly standard way (though – as we will see shortly – how these Case values corresponds to morphological realizations (=m-case), in particular for the Nominative [C]ase, is not as straightforward as one might assume). Before we come to that, however, let us discuss – in a preliminary way – Rackowski's assumptions about agreement in Tagalog. By “agreement”, I refer (as does Rackowski) to the varying morphological forms of verbs, as exemplified, for instance, by the set of examples in (1) from the introduction, which are repeated here.

- (5) a. N-agbigay si Juan ng bolsa kay Maria.
 AT.PERF.give UNM DEP dress OBL
 ‘Juan gave a dress to Maria.’
 b. Binigay-Ø ni Juan ang bolsa kay Maria.
 PERF.gave-UT DEP UNM dress OBL
 c. Binigy-an ni Juan ng bolsa si Maria
 PERF.give-DT DEP DEP dress UNM

Early work on Tagalog and the great variety of related languages of the Philippines held that the different forms of the verbs in (5) reflected alternations in voice. Thus, if one viewed Tagalog as a nominative-accusative language, (5a) would correspond to the active voice, and (5b) would correspond to the passive voice. Viewed as an ergative-absolutive language, (5a) would be an anti-passive, and (5b) would be an active sentence. What of (5c)? With this and related examples, it had to be concluded that Tagalog (viewed, for example, as a nominative-accusative language) has more than one type of passive-voice: One passive for when the verb’s theme/patient argument is promoted to SUBJECT*, and another for when a more ‘peripheral’ argument of the verb (e.g., a recipient, benefactive, or a locative) is promoted to SUBJECT*. In more contemporary studies, the view that the contrasts in verb morphology indicate voice have been largely abandoned as consensus (which I join) has developed that the language exemplifies a *symmetrical voice* system (Kroeger 1993, Foley 1998, Himmelman 2005, Riesberg 2014, Chen & McDonnell 2019, among others). On this view, the contrasting morphological forms must indicate some type of agreement as opposed to alternating voice (active/passive/anti-passive). The central question thus turns to what feature(s) are being agreed for.

In sharp contrast to agreement systems in more familiar languages (the Indo-European, Romance, Mayan languages), agreement in Tagalog and related languages does not involve the typical ϕ -features (person, number, gender). There are two main proposals concerning what the feature(s) of agreement are.

(6) **Agreement Features:**

- a. S-V agreement is for the θ -role feature of the SUBJECT*.
 (Kroeger 1993; Schachter & Otnes 1972; de Guzman 1978; Carrier 1985)
 b. S-V Agreement is for the Case feature of the SUBJECT*.
 (Pearson 2005, Rackowski 2002)

Before delving into the details of either of these proposals, let us first address the specific question of what elements are actually involved in agreement (i.e., what is the probe and what is the goal?). As the discussion already suggests, one of these elements is the SUBJECT*. Here and throughout, I refer to this element as SUBJECT* rather than simply saying subject because it has never been completely clear that the term can be used as the equivalent of the term when used to refer to subject in other languages. For Tagalog, it has also been referred to as the Topic, the Focus, and/or the Pivot. The reason for this confused terminology is likely related to the claim mentioned above that Tagalog is a symmetric voice language.

What this means, among other things, is that (5a) and (5b) are not likely active/passive/anti-passive alternates in the way that languages with a asymmetric voice system might have. Instead, the typical subject properties in Tagalog are distributed among the DP that is marked by *ang/si* (the [Unmarked]-case, as I will come to call it) and the external argument. Some of the typical “subject” properties of this DP include (see Koreger 1993, and Richards 1998, 2013 for relevant examples illustrating these properties):

- (7) a. Exclusive ability to undergo $\bar{A}$ -movement.
- b. Creates new binders for variable binding (repairing WCO)
- c. Sole ability to associated with floated quantifiers.
- d. Sole ability to trigger optional plural agreement.
- e. Sole ability to undergo Raising from embedded clause.
- f. Sole ability to associated with a secondary predicate.

Other subject properties (control of PRO, control of anaphors and bound variables, for example) are exclusively associated with the external argument, which may or may not also be the SUBJECT*. I therefore use the term SUBJECT* to refer to the DP that has the properties in (7), and which – crucial for our purposes – also appears to control agreement with respect to whatever feature ultimately ends up being relevant. Before we enter a discussion of these features, let us take a moment to ask – besides the SUBJECT*, what other element is involved in agreement. Rackowski assumes that the functional head that interacts with the SUBJECT* via Agree is T(ense). Although she does not provide a specific arguments for this, I concur and will add an empirical argument in support for this claim in the following subsection.

2.1. *T as the Probe for Agree*

The argument that T is the Probe for Agree with the SUBJECT* takes the following form: If we can find a context where T is plausibly absent, and show that in such contexts there is no agreement of the type that we find with verbs in paradigms like (5) above, then this would demonstrate that T is crucial to agreement. We should also find, in these context, that there is no unique DP bearing the *ang/si* case morphology.

The most likely candidate for a context where a verb would project with all of its arguments but not be dominated by T is absent is gerundive nominals. Gerunds come in roughly two broad types in Tagalog: Aspectless and Perfective (following the terminology of Schachter & Otanes 1972). Aspectless gerunds are typically formed with the prefix *pag-* and reduplication (plus the base), while perfective gerunds are typically formed by two pre-fixes *pag-ka-* attached to the base.³ Examples involving gerund formations are given in (8). Consider example (8a), which consists of the root *tugtog* (‘play’) in a nominalized (gerund) form. The examples in (9) contain the same root, but functioning as a verb rather than as a noun.⁴

³I have not been able to verify the accuracy of all of these forms, but suspect that they are subject to a certain degree of variation. Still, I provide these examples for a flavor of what the nominalizing morphology associated with gerunds looks like in general.

⁴I have glossed the highest argument within DP as GEN. I leave aside for now whether it should alternatively

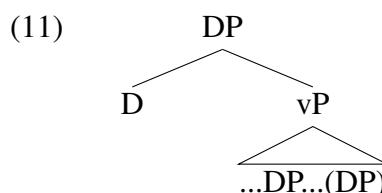
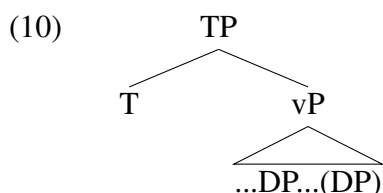
- (8) a. Mabilis ang [**pagtutugtog** niya ng piyesa].
fast SUBJ playing.NMLZ'N 3(SG(GEN)) DEP piece
'His playing of the piece is fast.'
- b. Sarap [**pagkaluto** nito] kasi malambot.
delicious NOML'N.PERF.COOK this(DEP) because soft
'It's delicious (after) having cooked this because it's tender.' (web, facebook)
- c. Ang [**pagpahaba** ng mga bestido] ay uso ngayon.
SUBJ lengthen.NMLZ'N DEP PL dress AY fashion now
'Lengthening of dress is fashion(able) now.' (English, 557)
- d. Ang [kanyang **paglilingkod** bilang kahilim ko] ay kasiya-siya.
SUBJ 3(SG.OBL) serve.NMLZ'M as secretary 1(SG(DEP)) AY satisfactory
'Her serving as my secretary is satisfactory.' (English, 825)
- e. Hindi natin maiiwasan [ang **pangunita** ng ating kabataan ...]
NEG 3PL(DEP) ABIL.UT.avoid UNM recall DEP 3PL(DAT) childhood
'We can't avoid recalling our childhood' (lit. the recalling of our childhood)
- (9) a. **Tumugtog** siya sa piyano ng isang napakagandang tugtugin.
PERF.AT.play 3sg(UNM) LOC piano DEP one.lk very.beautiful music
'She played a really beautiful composition on her piano.' (English, 1468)
- b. **Tinugtog-Ø** niya sa piyano ang paboritong kanta ng kanyang mga
PERF.play-TT 3sg(DEP) LOC piano UNM favorite.lk song DEP 3sg(DAT) PL
magulang.
song
'She played her parent's favorite songs on the piano.' (English, 1468)

As should be clear from the above examples, the gerund forms lack an unmarked DP (i.e., a SUBJECT*). Furthermore, for any given base, there is only one form that does not show any morphological indication of relationship between the morphology of the nominalized base and one of the arguments of that base. One could imagine otherwise. One could imagine, for instance, that the gerundivized form of the root *tugtog* ('play') in (8a) came in different forms depending on which DP argument it agrees with or which one is more prominent either in a structural sense or some information-structure based sense. But there are no forms like, for example, **p-um-agtugtog*/**pag-umugtog* or **p-in-agtugtog*/**pagt-in-ugtog* compared to the verbal forms in (9a), where the form in (9a) realizes the so-called 'ACTOR-TOPIC' form, and (9b) realizes a 'NON-ACTOR-TOPIC' form.

These facts can be understood assuming that gerunds contain a vP (a projection of the verb and its arguments) but lack T. In other words, vP may merge with either T or D (Abney 1987). When T is merged with vP, it Probes for a DP with vP to Agree with. Successful Agree between T and a(n) (unmarked) DP is then reflected by the specific morphological realization of the verb. When vP is instead merged with D, there is no unmarked DP and – by hypothesis – D, unlike T, does not seek a DP to Agree with. Because there is no agreement (involving D), there is a single invariant gerundive form rather than different

be analyzed as the same DEP-case associated with *ng/ni*-marked internal arguments.

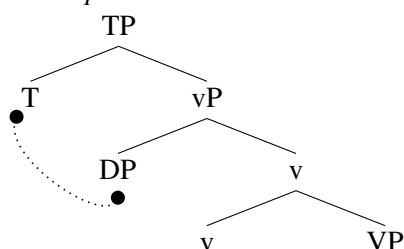
forms for different selections for a SUBJECT*.⁵



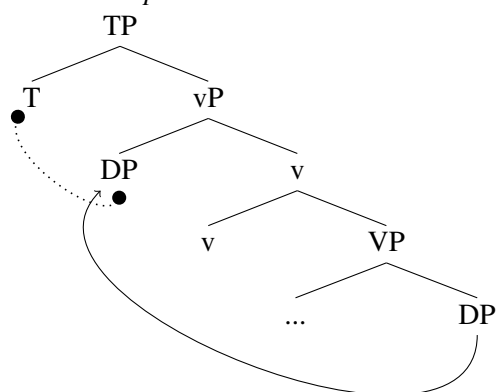
2.2. *T Agrees With Highest DP*

I will assume along with Rackowski that the DP that T agrees with is structurally the highest DP within vP and therefore the closest to T. For so-called **ACTOR TOPIC** sentences, this DP is the external argument. For **NON-ACTOR TOPIC** sentences, this is an internal argument of the verb after this argument has raised to the outer specifier of vP, above the external argument.

(12) *Actor Topic:*



(13) *Non-Actor Topic:*



See Rackowski (2002) and Richards and Racowski (2005) for arguments for this proposal. See Chen (2025) for an alternative proposal for agreement that does not involve movement of VP-internal arguments prior to Agree in **NON-ACTOR TOPIC** sentences, but leaves open the question of why the external argument may be skipped for purposes of this Agree. Nothing too crucial hangs on these details as far as agreement is concerned, but – if the Dependent Case-approach I will advocate proves to offer a better analysis of case, the raised internal argument is a crucial ingredient.

⁵Chen (2025) proposes that Agree involves a *composite chain*, where both C and T (probing for $\bar{A}$ and ϕ features, respectfully) are involved in the Agree relation. For reasons of space, I do not discuss her proposal in more detail in this paper. The conclusions and arguments reached in this paper do not seem to be overly changed with her proposal.

3 What Features Does Agree Target?

We have now reached the point of this paper where I wish to consider two of the extant answers to the question: What feature(s) does Agree (between T and the SUBJECT*) target? As previously mentioned, ϕ -features, though typically involved in agreement systems, are not the features that agreement targets in Tagalog.⁶ Two possibilities, besides ϕ , have been suggested in the literature. These were introduced in (6) above, and are repeated here.

(14) **Agreement Features:**

- a. S-V agreement is for the θ -role feature of the SUBJECT*.
(Kroeger 1993; Schachter & Otnes 1972; de Guzman 1978; Carrier 1985)
- b. S-V Agreement is for the Case feature of the SUBJECT*.
(Pearson 2001, Rackowski 2002)

Rackowski's work attempts to defend the view in (14b), that agreement involves what she refers to as Case-agreement (T targets the Case-feature assigned to the SUBJECT*). She presents two arguments for dismissing the preceding hypothesis (14a), according to which T targets the θ -features of the SUBJECT*. With respect to her more theoretical argument, she notes (footnote 2, pg. 106) that "the concept of θ -agreement ... seems to require the use of θ -features on arguments along the lines of Hornstein (1999)... [T]hat are conceptually difficult to justify." I do not find merit in this argument, as there is no explicit mention concerning what – exactly – is conceptually difficult to justify about the 'use of θ -roles on arguments'. In Section 4 of this paper, we will return to a discussion of what Rackowski might have had in mind here, but nevertheless develop an analysis involving θ -agreement based on the feature-based " θ -system" fleshed out in the work of Reinhart (2002, 2009, 2013).

Rackowski's second argument (see also Chen 2025) is empirical and potentially more persuasive. She notes that intransitive unaccusative verbs are inflected with the same agreement morphology that is used for transitive verbs in ACTOR TOPIC sentences. For instance, the unaccusative verb-base meaning 'fall', is expressed in a form that uses an (allomorph of) the form used in ACTOR TOPIC sentences – namely, *-um-/M-*.

- (15) *Tumamba ang bata.*
PERF.AT.fall UNM child
'The child fell.'

Compare (15) to (16) below. Here, the same base is used but this time in a transitive (causative) sentence corresponding to the intransitive (inchoative) form in (15).

- (16) *N-agtumba ng bata si Rosa.*
PERF.AF-pag-fall DEP child UNM
'Rosa knocked the child down.'

⁶Cf. Chen 2025, who argues for "abstract" ϕ -agreement.

Note that the verb in this ACTOR TOPIC sentence is inflected with the other allomorph of the ACTOR TOPIC morphology (i.e., *M-* rather than *-um-*), but assuming this is indeed simply allomorphy, whatever feature is being realized to express agreement with the SUBJECT* must be the same. Since the SUBJECT* bears the theme θ -role in (15) but the agent/cause θ -role in (16), this common feature of the DP most certainly cannot be a θ -role. If it were, we might expect the unaccusative verbs to be realized as forms like *sabog-in*, *darating-in* (i.e., the NON-ACTOR TOPIC form of the verb).⁷ Rackowski's solution to this problem is on the surface straightforward. It follows from (i) the assumption that the verb morphology is a realization of Case-agreement, coupled with (ii) Burzio's Generalization, or – more formally – the once standard view that unaccusative verbs (i.e. v_{unacc}) do not assign [Acc] Case (see also Chen 2025, who solves the present puzzle by appeal to BG). Putting aside questions of the empirical validity of Burzio's Generalization (concerning which, see Marantz 1991, Landau 2010, Baker & Vinokurova 2010, Šereikaiteė 2021, among others), it is plain that any proposal that treats Tagalog verbal morphology as reflecting agreement for θ -features must explain this basic empirical fact about unaccusatives. I return to this issue in Section 4.2.

3.1. Case Agreement

In this section, I attempt to fill out the details of the Case-agreement analysis proposed by Rackowski. It should be noted at the outset that I have had to fill in certain details left unelaborated in her work. I have attempted to remain as faithful to her proposal mainly by simply adding formally to it what her work leaves unformalized.

The Case-agreement proposal appears relatively straightforward at first glance, as it can be stated in two simple parts. The first part has to do with the assignment/valuation of Case on arguments, the second part has to do with the morphological realization (spell-out) of the Agree relationship between T and the Case-value of the SUBJECT*.

(17) Case Assignment/Valuation:

- a. T assigns [Nom] to highest DP without a Case-value;
- b. v (specifically, v_{trans} assigns [Acc] to closest DP without a Case-value;
- c. P (or a low Applicative head) assigned [Obl] to its complement.

(18) Realizations of Case-agreement (Rackowski 2002):

- a. Agree with [Nom] $\leftrightarrow \{/-um-/ , /N-/ \}$ ⁸
- b. Agree with [Acc] $\leftrightarrow /-in/ \{ /i-/ , /-an/ \}$ ⁹
- c. Agree with [Obl] (low applicative) $\leftrightarrow /-an/$

⁷Forms like *sabug-in* do exist, but they are transitive rather than intransitive. They are the forms expected when the verb realizes agreement with the internal rather than the external argument – i.e. where the Theme/Patient is the pivot in a so-called 'non-actor topic' form.

⁸Throughout, I will assume that these two morphemes are allomorphs.

⁹*/-in/* (or $\emptyset$ in [+realis]) is the default form, but the other affixes appear with certain lexical items without apparent cause or reason.

In the system she develops, the realization rules would apply (roughly) to T (or T which, by hypothesis, contains a raised V+v), which obtain a value for Case via Agree with the *SUBJECT**. Thus, a crucial ingredient of Rackowski's analysis involves a [uCase____] (unvalued, uninterpretable Case) feature for T, which is valued by Agree. This feature is formally represented in (19). (This is a slight departure from Rackowski's formalism which represents the same idea but with a feature [uCV].)

(19) T[uCase:____]

Something that is not immediately obvious here is how the Case-assignment rules in (17) relate to the actual morphological realization of case. One thing that must be true is that there is no direct, one-to-one, correspondence between a DP's abstract Case and its morphological case. Consider, for instance, the case marking of the DP *SUBJECT**, which is invariably /ang/ (for common nouns) or /si/ (for proper names), respectively. For Rackowski, this is not a [Nom]-case, as it could be the realization of a DP assigned [Acc]-case or [Obl]-case. Given this, it would seem as if the rule for realizing /ang/ or /si/ is the spell-out for case on the DP that specifically values a Case-feature on T. Thus, the realization rule for this case must be sensitive not just to the feature of what it spells out, but also how that feature was obtained. Such a rule might look something like (20).¹⁰

(20) $K \leftrightarrow \{ /ang/, si/ \} / \text{Agree}(T, ___)$

Now that we have (20), the remaining spell-out rules can be formalized as:

(21) a. $K \leftrightarrow /sa, kay/ / [Obl]$
b. $K \leftrightarrow /ng, ni/ / \text{elsewhere}$

Returning now to Rackowski's proposal concerning Case-agreement, let us begin with *ACTOR TOPIC* sentences. Recall that the external argument in such sentences (all sentences, in fact) is assigned [Nom] by T. At the same time, given the hypothesis of Case-agreement, T must also obtain a [Nom] Case-value. What this seems to entail is that, in addition to the [uCase]-feature of (19), T also has a valued [Nom] Case-feature. Since Case is uninterpretable, by hypothesis, I will represent this feature as [-iCase:Nom] (or [-iNom], for short). Thus, a fuller specification for T will be as shown in (23).

(22) $T \begin{bmatrix} -i\text{Case: Nom} \\ \text{uCase : } ___ \end{bmatrix}$

This feature of the analysis is a bit of a departure from the kinds of features proposed for probes, and seems to depart from the original idea behind Agree as it contains an uninterpretable-feature *with* a value (rather than an uninterpretable and unvalued feature). If

¹⁰On the use of K, see Paul et. al. (2015), and Collins (2018). I leave it as an open question for now whether this kind of contextual restriction is appropriate for realization rules in general. Since realization rules within Distributed Morphology (which I generally adopt here) tend to be formalized in a class SPE-style, there are few restrictions that the theory imposes on the context for application of the rule.

we grant this possibility for now, note that it is crucial at a minimum that the Grammar must come equipped with a restriction on feature bundles like (22) that, for this particular case, will prevent the [uCase]-feature from taking its value from the [-iCase]-feature. Without such a restriction, T could effectively value itself and thus make it inactive for Agree (recall condition (3a) above). It therefore seems necessary to stipulate a restriction such as the one in (23).

(23) **Prohibition on Self Valuation:**

If a probe has feature F and F', where F is valued but F' is unvalued, F' may not take its value from F.

Granting this stipulation, we can resume with the derivation leading to Case-agreement for an ACTOR TOPIC sentence. Since T has a [uCase] feature, it may initiate a search for a goal with a matching feature (i.e., a goal with a feature for [Case]). In the case of an ACTOR-TOPIC sentence, this will be the external argument, a DP which – by hypothesis – bears a [uCase] feature. This feature is valued [Nom] on the Goal by the [-iNom]-feature associated with T. Furthermore, the [Nom]-value that the goal now has can serve as the valuer of the [uCase]-feature on T. The copying of the Case-feature under Agree is illustrated in (24).

$$(24) \quad T \left[\begin{array}{l} -iCase: \text{Nom} \\ uCase : \text{Nom} \end{array} \right] \dots DP[uCase: \text{Nom}]$$

The resulting analysis, then, involves not self-valuing but a kind of *self-serving* Agree. Since self valuing is (by stipulation) impossible, the [Nom]-feature that T originally has cannot value its own [uCase]-feature. However, T can value a [uCase]-feature on the external argument which it can then use to value itself. T, then, gives the external DP something that it itself wants but can't give to itself even though it possesses the desired object. This is a rather complex interaction resulting from two sources: An Agree based analysis of valuing/assigning Case, and the hypothesis that agreement in Tagalog is agreement with the Case feature of the SUBJECT*. Viewed from the perspective of the original conception of Agree, this kind of interaction is less than ideal: In its original conception, a probe gives a goal something that the goal needs (e.g., a value for Case), and the goal gives the probe something that it needs (e.g., ϕ -features). Crucially, the needs of the probe and the goal are for values for distinct features rather than one and the same feature. That said, since the original formulation(s) of Agree did not stipulate a restriction like (23), self serving Agree cannot be theoretically ruled out. However, I am also unaware of any proposal within the literature that has this feature.

Problems for Rackowski's analysis are more acute when it comes to the derivation of UNDERGOER TOPIC sentences. Here, the relevant part of the derivation begins with T and a DP in the outer specifier of vP above the external argument.

$$(25) \quad T \left[\begin{array}{l} -iCase: \text{Nom} \\ uCase : \text{___} \end{array} \right] [_{vP} DP[uCase: \text{Acc}] DP[uCase: \text{___}] v VP]$$

Since T has a [uCase]-feature, it may initiate a search for a Goal. It encounters the internal argument which has raised to the position above the external argument. The raised internal argument has a valued [uCase]-feature by virtue of the Agree relationship it entered into with v. Under Chomsky's system for Agree, this would mean that the internal argument DP is not an 'active' Goal and should therefore not be able to enter into (any) Agree relationships. The conditions on Agree stated earlier in (3) (from Deal) do not include any such activity condition on the goal, as it seems to be the consensus that all that is required for Agree is a probe with features that can be valued/copied from a goal with a matching feature (Bejar 2008, Preminger 2014:134-136, Rodriguez 2004, Nevins 2004). If so, then T may therefore Agree with the raised internal argument and copy the Case-feature of this DP. We reach the following step in the derivation:

$$(26) \quad T \left[\begin{array}{l} -i\text{Case: Nom} \\ u\text{Case: Acc} \end{array} \right] \left[{}_{vP} DP[u\text{Case: Acc}] DP[u\text{Case: } ___] v VP \right]$$

At this point, the Probe has no more unvalued-features, and – therefore – should therefore become inactive (i.e., not require any further Agree). This derivation, however, leaves the external argument without a value for its own [uCase]-feature. Thus, Rackowski's system once again departs from the original strictures associated with Agree this time by allowing an inactive Probe to Agree. Agree between T and the external argument results in valuation of the latter's [uCase]-feature, as illustrated in (27).

$$(27) \quad T \left[\begin{array}{l} -i\text{Case: Nom} \\ u\text{Case: Acc} \end{array} \right] \left[{}_{vP} DP[u\text{Case: Acc}] DP[u\text{Case: Nom}] v VP \right]$$

To summarize, the Case-agreement analysis proposed by Rackowski (2002), in order to derive the results it aims to, must depart from the conditions set for the operation Agree. Primarily, the problem lies in the difficulty of maintaining the Activity Condition associated with Agree. One might reasonably argue, as does Deal (to appear) that the Activity Condition is problematic both theoretically as well as empirically.¹¹ Theoretically, it is problematic because of its close connection with the basic hypothesis about Agree, which is that the function of Agree is to have uninterpretable features eliminated, a hypothesis that can be independently shown to be flawed (see, e.g., Preminger 2014). Empirically, the Activity Condition is problematic because of the existence of phenomenon such as hyper raising (references); and agreement with more than one head (references). Given all of this, one might argue that if the Activity Condition is removed from conditions on Agree, then the Case-agreement analysis can be maintained unencumbered. This is not the solution, as any theory of Agree must have something to say about why *probing* occurs in the first place, and the parameters associated with when said probing terminates. In the theory developed by Deal (to appear) (see also Preminger 2014, Brennan & Erlewine to appear), probing is initiated when a probe has features that it can copy to itself (*init*(H), in Deal's theory), and the probing stops when the probe has satisfactorily copied those features from the Goal.

¹¹ At least, this is the case for Chomsky's Activity Condition applied to the goal in an Agree relationship.

Whether or not a probe is satisfied depends on its specific satisfaction condition (**sat**(H), in Deal's theory).

The more specific point here is that the problem with the Case-agreement analysis is not completely a result of Chomsky's original formulation of Agree, based on the valuing of uninterpretable features. Instead, it is a problem for a very basic element that must be part of any theory of Agree, which concerns the question of why Agree takes place at all – i.e., what initiates this operation? Whether it is a need to value features for elimination or simply an ability to copy certain types of features (to permit limited redundancy, according to Deal), there needs to be some 'trigger' to initiate the process. In the Case-agreement analysis, as noted above with focus on the derivation of NON-ACTOR TOPIC sentences, there is no compelling trigger for T to Agree with the external argument after it has agreed with the raised internal argument. Put in other words, it has no 'slot' for features to be copied into, or – to put it still differently – the probe is "satiated", and therefore should not require interaction with another element via Agree or any other operation.

3.1.2 Default or Inherent Case? One of the main sources of trouble for the Case-agreement hypothesis is the [-i:Nom]-feature associated with T. Recall that according to Rackowski, this feature is the source of Nom-case for the external argument. Although it does not meet the criterion for being a probe that would initiate Agree, if it were absent, and/or if it does not play a role in the valuing of Nom-Case, the external argument will wind up without a Case-value. In other words, for example the step in the derivation for the NON-ACTOR TOPIC sentence in (26) would be the final step, leaving the [uCase]-feature of the external argument unvalued and hence not eligible for deletion.

One possibility here to consider is that (26) is indeed the last step in the derivation, but that the [uCase]-feature of the external argument is valued by "default".¹² In theory, this would allow for the elimination of the [-iNom]-feature from Rackowski's analysis, and permit Case-agreement to involve simply the valuing of Case-feature onto T. Specifically, re-consider the derivation step in (28), with DP's [uCase] filled in as a default [Nom_{Def}], and where [-iCase:Nom] is taken out of the equation.

(28) T[uCase:___]: ... DP[uCase:NOM_{Def}]

Agree between T and DP yields (29), with the Nom-feature of the DP providing the value for the [uCase]-feature of T.

(29) T[uCase: **Nom**]: ... DP[uCase:Nom_{Def}]

Elimination of the [-iNom]-feature of T in conjunction with the idea of default case will also allow for a simplification to the derivation and representation of UNDERGOER SENTENCES. The stage in the derivation represented by (30) is now:

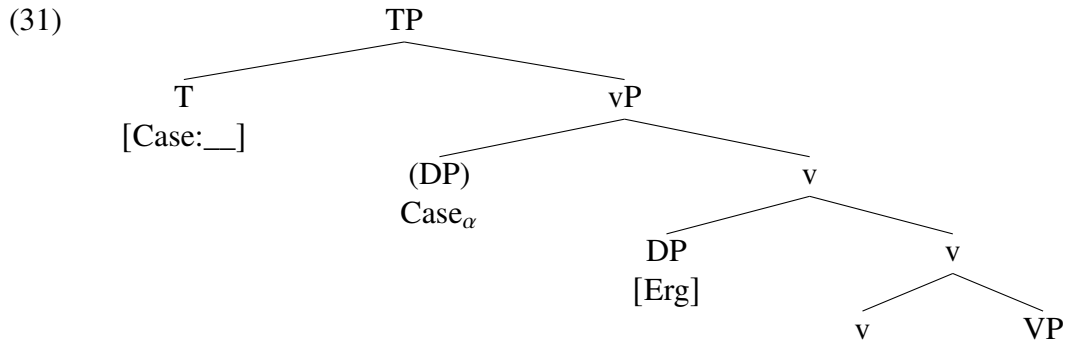
(30) T[uCase: **Acc**] [_{VP} DP[uCase: Acc] DP[uCase: Nom_{Def}] v VP]

¹²Alternative, it has a different source of Case all together, such an inherent Case. I consider this possibility next.

While the introduction of the idea of Nom being a default (not assigned by T) allows for a more streamlined Case-agreement analysis, it cannot be maintained. Firstly, this is because in practice, the term default case refers to a morphological case that appears on a DP when that DP cannot get case assigned through ‘normal’ syntactic mechanisms (Schütze 2001). While it is true that the posited default case is being assigned because there is no (active) probe to assign case to the external argument, this disruption to the “normal syntactic mechanisms” of Case-assignment is by design of the system upholding the Case-agreement hypothesis (i.e., it is a problem created by the system, and therefore not independent of that system). Second, and most critically, default case as argued by Schütze (2001) is not intended to “save” an otherwise illicit syntactic representation. Put differently, default case is invisible to the syntax. Hence, if valuation of a [uCase]-feature is necessary to a legitimate syntactic derivation, default case (a purely morphological phenomenon) will not help to satisfy the *syntactic* conditions that require it to be valued. Third and finally, default case if it were at play here would not be limited to a single morphological realization. In ACTOR TOPIC sentences, it would be realized as *ang/si* (the [Unm]-form), whereas for NON-ACTOR TOPIC sentences, it would be realized as *ng/ni* (the [Dep]-form). In all instance that I am aware of where default case is proposed, there is usually only a single designated case form used as the morphological exponent (e.g., it is Accusative in English, Nominative in German).

In sum, default case is part of a broader issue within Case theory, involving the separation between the concept of (abstract) Case responsible for ‘licensing’ DPs, and case as a purely morphological phenomenon (i.e., Case vs. case). Any proposal to amend Rackowski’s Case-agreement analysis by stipulating that the external argument (always) receives default case not only blurs the lines of this important distinction and runs the risk of rendering the concept of default case (or abstract Case, if this is maintained as a licensing requirement) meaningless.

Another alternative one might be inclined to consider is one in which we view Tagalog as an ergative-absolutive language, as in Aldridge (2004, 2008, 2010) and suppose that the external argument is assigned *inherent* ergative-case. Concretely, Aldridge proposes that in transitive clauses in Tagalog (=NON-ACTOR TOPIC-sentences in her ergative-absolutive analysis of the language) that *v* assigns inherent case to the external argument. She assumes, following the lead of authors such as Legate (2006, 2008, 2012) and Woolford (1997, 2006) that inherent ergative case is related to the assignment of an Agent or Agent-like θ -role to the external argument. Supposing this much, but putting aside for the moment the Case associated with the internal argument (if any), consider the following configuration.



Next, we might suppose Case-Agreement initiated by T with unvalued Case. In an UT-sentence (a transitive sentence, under the ergative-absolutive analysis of Aldridge), T agrees with the raised DP and has its Case valued as α , the Case value of this DP. In an ACTOR-TOPIC sentence where the ergative DP/external argument closest to T, T Agrees with this DP and has its Case valued as Erg. The relevant verb inflections might then be realized according to the following rules (modified from (18) above to fit the alternative under consideration).

- (32)
- a. Agree with $[Case_\alpha] \leftrightarrow \{/i-, -in-, -an/\}$
 - b. Agree with $[Erg] \leftrightarrow \{-um-, M-\}$

Note that under this analysis, T is not involved at all in assignment of Case, and hence there is no need to appeal to the problematic $[-iNom]$ -feature. Still, we can demonstrate the inadequacy of the proposal, which resides in the assumption of inherent (ergative) Case assigned to the external argument. The first problem concerns applicative of unaccusatives. Tagalog and many languages with a WAAS make robust use of applicatives to promote a non-core argument or even certain types of non-arguments to argument status. Consider, for instance, the verb whose root is *patay* ('die'). It is possible to optionally express a location or time with this eventuality, as in (33).

- (33) Tayong lahat ay mamamatay sa bunok na ito.
 1PL(UNM).LK all INV AT.CONT.die LOC mountain LK this
 'We will all die on this mountain.'

The optional locative here can become a core argument of the clause through applicativization, which in the case of locative applicatives typically involves the addition of the suffix *-an*. Note that unlike applicatives in other languages where a non-core argument becomes an internal argument (i.e. direct object) when applied, in Tagalog the applied argument must be promoted to a SUBJECT*-role. Consider (34).

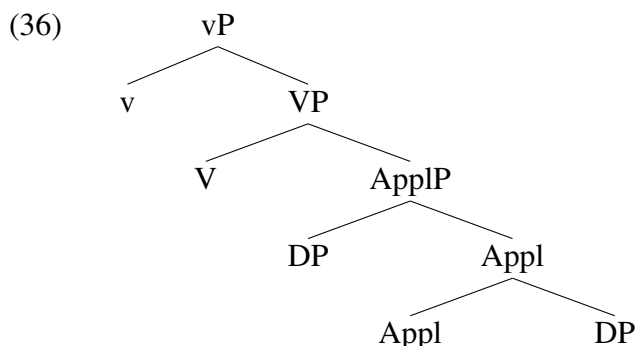
- (34) Papatay-an natin ang bundok na ito.
 CONT.die-APPL.LOC 1PL(DEP) UNM mountain LK this
 'We will die on this mountain.'

Crucially, the introduction of the applied locative imposes a *ng/ni*-case form, identical to the case of the external argument in NON-ACTOR TOPIC sentences. This casts serious doubt

on the possibility that this particular case form is a realization of an inherent ergative case, assigned in tandem with an Agent-like θ -role. The [Dep]-marked DP in these examples (presumably, an internal argument of the verb) cannot be assigned Case by the normal route by which internal arguments of ordinary transitive verbs is assigned Case (e.g., by v_{trans}). In their non-applicative forms, the verb's internal argument can never be marked with [Dep]-case/Case by v .

- (35) a. *Pumatay* tayo sa bundok na ito.
 CONT.die 1PL(UNM) LOC mountain LK this
 'We will die on this mountain.'
- b. **Pumatay* natin sa bundok na ito.
 CONT.die-APPL.LOC 1PL(UNM) LOC mountain LK this
 'We will die on this mountain.'

Since it cannot be that the verb's internal argument is assigned case by whatever would assign case in a typical transitive sentence, the only source available for case (putting aside the DC-approach for the moment) would be that it is assigned inherent case. If so, however, this would go far beyond what inherent case is intended to do, which is assign ergative case to external arguments concomitant with the Agent/Agent-like θ -role associated with the external argument.¹³ The [Dep]-case on the verb's internal argument here does follow here, however, given the DC-approach to be offered in Section 4.1. Applicativization has the function of adding a peripheral argument or non-argument to the clause, as illustrated in (36), which argument can then stand in competition for [Dep]-case with other DPs that are projected as part of the argument structure.



The fact that the applicative can apply to unaccusative is problematic from the inherent (ergative) case analysis of Tagalog, but not for the DC-approach (see Section 4.1).

As a final reason I will give to be doubtful of the inherent case possibility, we should note that it is primarily (if not only) ergative-absolutive languages where this type of case has been proposed. Although I cannot attempt to review the debates let alone settle the matter, it has been a rather contentious question for Tagalog whether the language has an ergative-absolutive alignment, or a nominative-accusative one. Most outspoken on this question

¹³For the general form of this argument, see Baker and Bobaljik 2015.

is Aldridge (2002, 2008, 2012), who advocates for an ergative-absolutive analysis of the language. Of her arguments, the main one seems to be that the type of sentence I have been referring to as *ACTOR TOPIC* is, in fact, an anti-passive construction – i.e., an intransitive type of sentences in which the verb’s internal argument is demoted to oblique status and the external argument is, in a sense, the only true argument of the verb (and hence, the absolutive *SUBJECT**). However, the evidence for analyzing a sentences like (54) an anti-passive are rather scant.

- (37) *Bumasag si Juan ng salamin.*
 AT.PERF=break UNM DEP mirror
 ‘Juan broke a mirror.’

One of Aldridge’s main arguments for an anti-passive analysis of (37) involves an often-cited claim that the (putative) direct object of *ACTOR TOPIC* sentences must be indefinite/non-specific, a property observed for anti-passives in other languages (see, e.g., Mithun). This claim, however, is refuted in Sabbagh (2016) who provides numerous examples demonstrating that direct objects in *ACTOR TOPIC* sentences may be (explicitly) specific.

- (38) *At kaya gusto ko-ng manalo ng award na ito.*
 and so want 1(SG(UNM))-1k to.win DEP award 1k this
 ‘and so I want to win this award.’
 (Sabbagh 2016:647, example (11))

I conclude therefore that an ergative-absolutive analysis for Tagalog cannot is not appropriate.¹⁴ If this is the case, then any ‘pay out’ that might be gained from assigning inherent ergative case to the external argument is unlikely to follow.

3.2 Interim Conclusion

To summarize thus far: I have argued that the agreement morphology that is realized on the verb does not target the Case-feature of the DP that agrees with T. My argument does not rest on the assumption that Case-features could not be targeted by Agree in general (e.g., as a subset of the ϕ -features), but that an operation, Agree, that is by hypothesis also involved in assigning/valuing Case cannot at the same time target those features for agreement, at least – not without significant revision to theory of Agree.

4 Tagalog Case in a Dependent Case Framework

In this section, I propose an analysis of case and agreement in Tagalog that does not encounter the complex set of issues that arise under the Case-agreement analysis. The analysis that I will propose has two components. First, I develop an analysis of morphological case

¹⁴That is not to say that I am therefore arguing for a nominative-accusative analysis either. As I have tried to make clear in the main text, neither type of analysis is particularly useful.

that is couched within the framework of a Dependent Case-approach (DC-approach), argued for Martantz (1991) and defended at length by McFadden 2004 (see also, most recently: Baker 2014, 2015, 2017; Baker & Bobaljik 2017; Baker & Vinokurova 2010; Bobaljik 2008). Second, I propose an analysis of agreement in Tagalog based on an older idea from the literature that agreement involves semantic/ θ -roles. Because Agree is not involved in the assignment/valuation of [C]ase, and because it does not target [C]ase-features, the analysis I propose does not encounter the technical problems that Rackowski's Case-agreement proposal does in its implementation.

4.1. A Dependent Case Approach to Tagalog Case

Recall that Tagalog contrasts three morphological cases: One of these, what I will refer to as the Oblique ([Obl]), surfaces on Goal/Recipient/Locative-type arguments of three place predicates.¹⁵

- (39) N-ag-hagis ng bola si Juan *kay Maria*.
 PERF-AT-TOSS GEN/ACC ball UNM OBL
 'Juan tossed a ball to Maria.'

The case that I have glossed as Dependent ([Dep]) is the most widespread in its distribution. It appears on internal arguments (see (39)) and on the external argument (see (40)) when these do not function as the SUBJECT*.

- (40) I-hinigas ni Juan ang bola *kay Maria*.
 TT-.PERF.throw DEP UNM ball OBL
 'Juan tossed the ball to Maria.'

It also appears on all DP-internal arguments that are not otherwise marked [Obl] in nominalizations.

- (41) Hindi natin maiiwasan [ang **pangunita** ng *ating kabataan* ...]
 NEG 3PL(DEP) ABIL.UT.avoid UNM recall DEP 3PL(DAT) childhood
 'We can't avoid recalling our childhood' (lit. the recalling of our childhood)

This same case form is used to mark (post-nominal) possessors in possessive DPs, as shown in (42).

- (42) a. asawa ni Juan
 spouse GEN
 'Juan's spouse'
 b. guro ng estudyante
 teacher GEN student
 'the student's teacher'

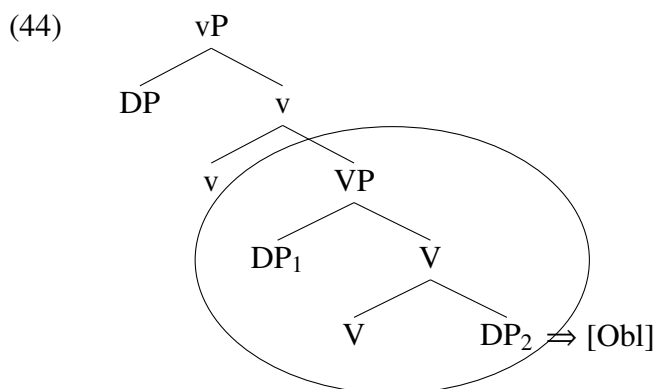
¹⁵I use the term 'oblique' as a catch all term to describe peripheral arguments as well as some non-arguments. Morphologically, they are all realized by the same case morpheme: *sa* (common nouns) or *kay* (proper names).

It is unclear at the present time, however, whether the case marking found here with possessors is the same in terms of features as the case that I call [Dep]. In particular, it may specifically instantiate something like Genitive ([Gen]-)case. I will not discuss this case and its properties further, but will focus instead just on those environments reviewed above where I analyze the case-marking as [Dep]-case – i.e., in verbal clauses. Thus, putting aside the (possible) [Gen]-case, the distribution of [Obl] and [Dep]-case may be captured by the following algorithm.

- (43) **Dependent Case Rule:** Given two DPs (DP_1 and DP_2) with a Domain D , such that DP_1 c-commands DP_2 (and DP has not been assigned case):
- Assign [Obl] to DP_2 if DP_1 and DP_2 are (externally) merged within the same spell-out domain;
 - Assign [Dep] otherwise to DP_2 within D .

I will assume, for the purposes of this work, that the spell-out domain is the complement of a phase head: For instance, VP, which is a complement to the phase head v , is a spell-out domain; TP, which is the complement to the phase head C is a spell-out domain; and so on. As far as I can tell, alternative definitions of spell-out domain can be adopted here as well.

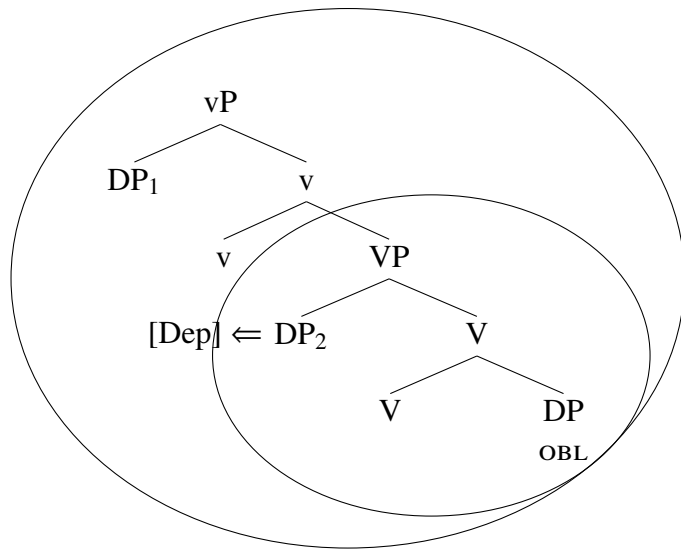
To illustrate how the algorithm in (43) applies, consider sentence (39), for which I assume the following (sub-)structure.¹⁶



Since VP is a spell-out domain and DP_1 and DP_2 are both (initially) merged within this domain, rule (43a) applies and assigns/marks [Obl]-case to the lower of the two DPs. At the point at which the vP is (fully) constructed, the algorithm in (43) applies again. This time, the two DPs that are in contention for case are the external argument (DP_1 in (45)) and DP_2 , which resides in VP's specifier is the verb's Theme/Patient argument. Rule (43) does not apply since DP_1 and DP_2 are merged in different spell-out domains (vP for DP_2 , the next higher spell-out domain (e.g., CP) for DP_1). Rule (43b) does apply, and marks DP_2 as a dependent case ([Dep]).

¹⁶Earlier in this paper, I suggested that case may be realized as an instantiation of a K head dominating DP. This KP structure is not represented in the illustrations that follow, but can be assumed.

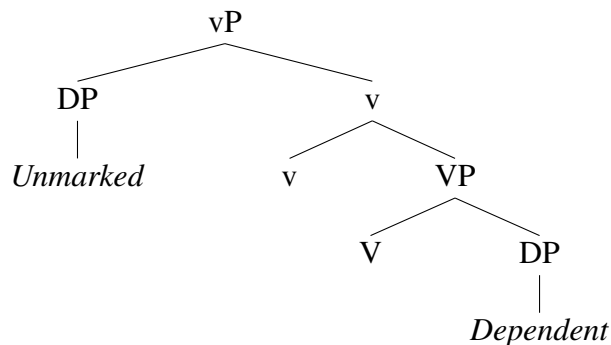
(45)



The DP in (45) that remains without case (=the SUBJECT*), I will assume is assigned unmarked-case ([Unm]). Consider a simple two place predicate associated with a single internal argument (e.g., a Theme/Patient). Putting aside lexical case and differential object marking (see Sabbagh 2016), this argument will always be marked with [Dep]-case rather than [Obl]). This follows from the algorithm in (43) since at the level of VP, there is only a single DP corresponding to the verb's internal argument. It is only at the vP level that there are two DP's, the internal and the external argument, and by (43b), the internal argument will be assigned [Dep]-case.

- (46) *Bumasag si Juan ng salamin.*
 AT.PERF.break UNM DEP mirror
 'Juan is breaking a mirror.'

(47)



4.2. *θ-Role Agreement Redux*

Recall that Rackowski's main objection to this proposal is theoretical by claiming that it is "conceptually difficult to justify". Although she does not fully articulate what this means exactly, I believe what she has in mind here is the idea that the traditional θ -roles (AGENT,

THEME/PATIENT, GOAL, EXPERIENCE, etc.) are not features that are associated with DPs (or PPs) in the way that, say, ϕ -features (Person, Number, Gender, and possibly Case) are (though cf. Lasnik 1995, Kim 1997, Hornstein (1999), who suggest otherwise). At the time of her writing, there was also an emerging approach which took the traditional θ -roles to be defined configurationally (see, e.g., Hale & Keyser 1993, Baker 1995). Under these theories, there are not even θ -roles per se, as the interpretation of a DP (as Agent or Theme/Patient) is determined by (or is a function of) the syntactic configuration in which a given DP occurs (a DP occupying Spec, vP is an Agent; a DP sister of V is a Theme; and so on.) More generally, agreement for θ -roles could be viewed as ‘conceptually difficult to justify’ because it had never been terribly clear since their introduction in Chomsky (1981) how – if at all – they are to be represented as part of a syntactic representation. Since agreement (Agree) needs access to information (features) that are encoded in a syntactic representation (ϕ -features perhaps being the best exemplar), if there is no theory of how θ -roles are represented then it is, indeed, difficult to justify the idea that process like Agree could make reference to them.¹⁷

The conceptual problem begins to fade, I believe, if one takes seriously the θ -system proposed by Tanya Reinhart in Reinhart (2002, 2012, 2016) (see also, Mararej 2002, 2016; Hoarvath & Siloni 2016). There, she proposes – taking much insight from Dowty’s (1991) seminal piece of Proto-(θ -)Roles – that traditional θ -roles can be analyzed as a feature system. In particular, she identified the features /c (=cause change) and /m (=mental state). The features combine in single matrix, referred to as a feature-cluster. Focussing just on those clusters identified with [+] and [-] attributes, the four logical possibilities include:

- (48) **Reinhart’s θ -System** (partial)
- a. [+c, +m] ($\approx$ Agent)
 - b. [-c, +m] ($\approx$ Experiencer)
 - c. [+c, -m] ($\approx$ Causer)
 - d. [-c, -m] ($\approx$ Theme/Patient)

Clusters can also be unary, meaning that they are specified as [+] or [-] for one feature /c or /m, but not the other. For instance, the traditional Goal θ -role is analyzed as [-c], meaning not a cause of change; but left unspecified for whether or not it is [+m] or [-m]. For Reinhart’s system, these feature cluster serve are present in the syntactic representation – e.g. on lexical items selected from the lexicon, which serves as an input to the Interfaces (the Inference (semantic) and Context (pragmatic) interface). Thus, these clusters are part of a lexical entry of a verb, but also representable on the phrase that express that role (e.g., on DPs and PPs). A verb such as break (Tagalog *basag*) is listed in the lexicon as:

- (49) **BREAK**, <[+c, $\pm$ m], [-c, -m]>

¹⁷Of course, there are privative features, and so θ -roles could be viewed as privative. However, this does not improve the situation for the traditional labels for θ -roles which are independently known to be too coarse and not amenable to the formulation of natural classes (see, e.g., Dowty 1989).

If θ -Roles are analyzed in terms of these feature clusters and relevant to the interface between syntax and semantics, they are by hypothesis part of the syntactic representation. In fact, Reinhart puts these feature to use in analyzing various verb alternations (causative/inchoative alternations, alternations involving psych-verbs, and so on) as well part of a theory of Case. If they are a part of the syntactic representation, they should in principle be visible and, more importantly, *usable* for various systems within the language, including subject-verb agreement (more formally, Agree[T, DP]). I propose that this is exactly what occurs in Tagalog and other ‘Philippine-type’ WAAV systems. Specifically, I hypothesize that T bears unvalued θ -features, [$u\theta$:___], which will become valued when T enters into an Agree relationship with a DP that has bares these as valued features, which then get copied onto T. Illustrative derivations of the Agree system based here on Reinhart’s θ -system are provided in Section 4.3. For now, let us tentatively close by restating the morphological realization rules for the morphology of in terms of these θ -features, as follows (compare to (18)).

(50) θ -Agreement (Reinhart inspired):

- a. $T[\theta:-c, -m] \leftrightarrow /-in/, (i-, -an)$
- b. $T[\theta-c] \leftrightarrow /-an/$
- c. $T[\theta:+c]^{18} \leftrightarrow \{/-um-/ , /M-/\}$

Note that the realization rules in (50) are subject to the problem that Rackowski noted for clauses formed around an unaccusative verb. Recall that the problem with these cases is that unaccusative verbs, with a sole [-c, -m] ($\approx$ Theme/Patient θ -role) are always inflected with /-um-/ or /M-/, but – crucially – are never realized by the morphology that is used for when the verb’s internal theme argument is the subject (i.e., /-in/). A straightforward, all be it admittedly descriptive, solution to this would be to add a contextual restriction to rules (51a, b) such that they apply only when in configuration where they are local to another DP (in particular, the external argument). In effect, this makes rule (51c) realizing /-um-/ as the elsewhere case.

(51) θ -Agreement (Reinhart inspired, *final version*):

- a. $T[\theta:-c, -m] \leftrightarrow /-in/, (i-, -an) / \text{---} \overset{\text{DP}}{[\text{Case}_\alpha]}$
- b. $T[\theta-c] \leftrightarrow /-an/ / \text{---} \overset{\text{DP}}{[\text{Case}_\alpha]}$
- c. $T[\theta] \leftrightarrow \{/-um-/ , /M-/\} \text{---} \overset{\text{DP}}{[-]}$

(For $\alpha = [\text{Dep}], [\text{Obl}]; [-] = \text{Unmarked}$)

4.3 Derivations

¹⁸On Agents versus Causers.

In this section, I present the workings of the overall system for case assignment and agreement that I have developed thus far. Let us begin with the derivation of the ACTOR-TOPIC sentence in (52).

- (52) *Bumasag si Juan ng salamin.*
 AT.PERF=break UNM DEP mirror
 ‘Juan broke a mirror.’

The derivation begins with the Merge of the verb and its [-c,-m] complement, as in (53a). No case is valued at this point since there is only a single DP. Next, *v* is merged above the VP and the external argument is introduced (which is [+c, +m] in this case). Next, as shown in (53c), *T* is merged and undergoes Agree with the highest DP (=the external argument) copying this DP’s θ -features. Finally, the structure is spelled out at PF, where case and agreement are both realized.

- (53) a. **Merge V+Theme:** [_{VP} V DP[-c,-m]]
 b. **Merge v+EA:** [_{VP} DP[+c,+m] v [[_{VP} V DP[-c,-m]]]
 c. **Merge T+vP:** T[θ :____] [_{VP} DP[+c,+m] v [[_{VP} V DP[-c,-m]]]
Agree: → T[θ : [+c,+m]] [_{VP} DP[+c,+m] v ...
 d. **Spell-Out:** T{ -um- } [_{VP} DP[UNM] [v [_{VP} V DP[DEP]]]

The derivation of a ACTOR TOPIC sentence will begin the same with steps (53a,b). It differs, however, in that the internal argument moves out of the VP to a position just above the external argument, yielding (54a). Merge of *T* with the vP initiates Agree between *T* and the internal argument. Spell-Out produces the morphological forms for case and agreement shown in (54c).

- (54) a. **Move of Internal Argument:** [_{VP} DP[-c,-m]_i DP[+c,+m] v [[_{VP} V *t_i*]]
 b. **Merge T+vP:** T[θ :____] [_{VP} DP[-c,-m]_i DP[+c,+m] v [[_{VP} V *t_i*]]
Agree: → T[θ : [-c,-m]] [_{VP} DP[-c,-m] DP[+c,+m] v ...
 c. **Spell-Out:** T{ -in } [_{VP} DP[UNM] DP[DEP] v ...

Finally, consider example (55), with an unaccusative verb.

- (55) *Sumabog ang gulsali.*
 PERFexplode UNM building
 ‘The building exploded.’

Here, the derivation begins with a VP with a verb and a [-c,-m] complement DP; to which *v* is merged (see (56a)). Since this is an unaccusative structure, no external argument (with features [+c,+m]) will be introduced, and therefore the case of the DP is [Unm] (Case:[-]). As shown in (56a), *T* is then merged with this vP and Agree is initiated. Spell-Out applies yielding the morphological form given in (56b).

- (56) a. **Merge T+vP:** $T[\theta: ___] \text{ } [_{VP} \vee [[[_{VP} V DP[-c, -m]]]]$
Agree: $\rightarrow T[\theta: [-c, -m]] \text{ } [_{VP} \vee [[[_{VP} V DP[-c, -m]]]]$
b. **Spell-Out:** $T\{-um-\} \text{ } [_{VP} \vee [VP V DP[UNM]]]$

4.4. Summary and Discussion

In this section, I have proposed a DC-approach to case in Tagalog, and put forward a proposal to analyze the agreement morphology of the verb in terms of θ -agreement, developed with the system of θ -features proposed in Reinhart (2002, 2008, 2006). While I have not explicitly considered various other alternatives along the way, I do hope to have demonstrated the superiority of θ -agreement as opposed to Case-agreement. The main simplification that I have introduced involves eliminating the need for a probe (e.g., T) that simultaneously need to value and receive a value for a singular feature, F, on the same application of Agree. I am unaware of any instances of Agree (proposed in the literature) that has this type of property, suggesting perhaps that it does not occur in natural languages.

One topic that I have not yet touched on concerns the place in Grammar where case and agreement (via Agree) are calculated. Bobaljik (2008), who assumes the DC-approach to case, argues that if agreement must ever make reference to case, then – given that case is assigned in the morphological component – then so too must agreement. In my proposal, agreement and case interact in a limited way: Agree (i.e., θ -agreement) is always with the DP that *unmarked* for case. Given this, based on the arguments in Preminger (2014:Chapter 9), there is no “ordering argument” to be made here that agreement and case both must occur in the morphological component (i.e., are post-syntactic). In fact, it may turn out that case assignment and agreement can be assumed to apply in the syntax. For instance, Poole (2024) devises a system that allow case to be assigned by Agree in the syntax, while also maintaining the core insights of the DC-approach (see also Clem & Deal 2025). I will not develop his system for Tagalog here for reasons of space. Suffice it to say, wherever things land with these larger architectural issues, I hope to have demonstrated what goes wrong when a probe targets a goal to both assign a Feature to the goal, and simultaneously, take from that goal a value for the same feature. As long as agreement in Tagalog does not target Case-features, any reasonable theory of how those features are obtained on DPs should be irrelevant.

5 Existential Construction and Null Epletives

In this section, I discuss the cases of an existential construction in Tagalog that seem to be problematic for the DT-approach developed in this work. What makes this constructions seemingly problematic is the presence of a *ng/ni* marked DP (the proposed [Dep]-case) in the absence of a DP with [Unm]-case. I will suggest a solution to this problem by hypothesizing a syntactically present but phonologically vacuous expletive, pro_{exp} . The presence of this expletive makes [Dep]-case assignment possible where it would otherwise be unex-

pected. Related constructions in other languages are discussed as well, for which the pro_{exp} or something akin to it has been proposed.

5.1 The Eventive Existential Constructions

In Sabbagh (2009), I analyze a common type of existential constructions in Tagalog that I will refer to here as the aspectless (or, stative) existential construction. At its core, this existential is formed around a predicate *may* ('exists'), which may or may not be associated with a meaningless form of the locative element *roon* ('there, in it'). Consider the examples in (57).

- (57) a. May **isang aktibistang tinawag** siyang "baluktot na artist".
 exist one.LK activist.LK PERF.PV.call 3SG(UNM).LK crooked LK artist
 'There was one activist who (they) called him: "crooked artist"'
- b. Mayroon pang **ibang mga dahilan** na puwedeng magpataas ng
 exist.there yet.LK other.LK PL reasons that can.LK increase DEP
 inyong presyon ...
 blood.LK pressure
 'There are other reasons blood pressure increases...'
- c. Mayroong **mga batas** na puprotekta sa iyo laban sa diskriminasyon
 exist.there PL laws LK protect OBL you against OBL discrimination
 sa lugar na pinasasukan.
 LOC place LK work
 'There are laws that will protect you against discrimination in the workplace.'
 (<https://www.justice.gov/crt/page/file/972296/dl>)

The primary DP argument in these existential sentences (also known as the 'pivot') is not marked for case (in fact, it cannot be so marked). In Sabbagh (2009), I argue that the lack of case-marking is related to the hypothesis that the pivot has composed, semantically, with the existential predicate by Restrict (Chung & Ladusaw 2001). In other words, the pivot is a pseudo-incorporated DP that functions semantically like a predicate rather than as an argument (Massam 2001, Barrie & Li 2015).¹⁹ I will assume, without exploring the matter in more detail, that this basic idea carries over to the present work and that DPs that compose with their predicate via Restrict (and hence, become incorporated into the predicate) do not fall under the per-view of the rules of case-assignment.²⁰

Alongside aspectless existential sentences like (57), there is also an existential construction whose primary argument is marked for case, in particular, [Dep]-case. These existential constructions are formed around an affix *magka-* (>N+pag-ka-) prefixed to the vacuous locative *roon*. Crucially, the predicate can be inflected for all of the major aspects that ordinary verbal predicates may be inflected for (i.e., (im)perfective, contemplative, recent perfective).

¹⁹Possibly, if we take case morphology to instantiate a K-head that selects DP, the absence of case in these could be attributed to the absence of a K head.

²⁰The verb *gusto* ('want') might be another example of an incorporating verb in Tagalog.

- (58) a. Bakit nagkakaroon [ng altapresyon]?
 why IMPERF.exist.there DEP high-blood-pressure
 ‘Why does high blood pressure occur?’
- b. Tag-ulan na: Magkakaroon ba [ng customer] sa coffee shop?
 from-rain now: CONT.exist.there Q DEP customer LOC coffee shop
 ‘It’s the rainy season now: Will there be customers at the coffee show?’
- c. Noong 1935, nagkaroon [ng pagbabago] na nagdulot ng napakalaking
 in 1935 PERF.exist.there DEP change LK altered DEP greatly
 epekto sa paraan ng pagdiriwang ng mga Ruso ng kapaskuhan.
 way OBL
 ‘In 1935, a change occurred that profoundly altered the way Russians marked
 the holiday season.’
 (<https://glosbe.com/tl/en/nagkaroon>)

The examples above are instantiations of what I will refer to as the *eventive existential* construction, to contrast it with the aspectless existential constructions like those in (57). Important for what follows, the eventive existential predicate may occur with an additional argument, in which case the constructions expresses a possessive relation between this argument and the pivot, or – in certain instances – signifies the affectedness of the argument. Some relevant examples are given in (59).²¹

- (59) a. Ngunit nitong huli, nagkaroon na [ng masamang epekto] ang kanyang
 but this.lk late perf.exist.there prt DEP bad.lk effect UNM his.lk
 “bisyo”.
 vice
 ‘But lately, his “vice” has had a bad effect.’
- b. Bakit nagkakaroon [ng cancer] ang isang tao?
 why IMPF.exist.there DEP cancer UNM one.lk person
 ‘Why does a person have cancer?’ (or, why does a person get cancer?)
 (<https://www.abs-cbn.com/news/health-science/2025/2/12/alaman-bakit-nagkakaroon-ng-cancer-ang-isang-tao-1842>)
- c. Sana ay nagkaroon kami [ng impormasyong ito] noon,...
 wish INV PERF.exist.there 1PL.OBL(UNM) DEP information.LK this then
 ‘I wish we had had that informed then.’
 (<https://glosbe.com/tl/en/nagkaroon>)

Examples like (58), in contrast to the examples in (59), seem to pose a problem for the DT-approach put forward here (specifically, the case-assigning rules in (43)).²² This is

²¹I have not systematically investigated the full range of semantic relations of the ‘external argument’ DP in these possessive-like examples.

²²Note that the examples are problematic as well for a Agree-based analysis of Case-assignment/licensing, which would ordinarily stipulate that it is *v* that assigns [Acc]-Case to a verb’s internal argument. Such analyses typically also stipulate that *v* assigns Case only if it additionally licenses an external argument (i.e., if it is transitive) but not if it is an unaccusative with only a single VP-internal argument.

because in the absence of any other argument, the ‘pivot’ of the existential sentences in (58) would not be predicted to be marked with the case that realizes [Dep]-case. Only in the presence of another DP argument, as in the examples in (59) would we expect [Dep]-case for the pivot.

The problem posed by the eventive existential is not unique to Tagalog, however. Greek existential sentence formed around the existential verb *exi* likewise exhibit accusative case marking on their pivot in the absence of an overt unmarked (nominative) DP (Kampanarou 2024).

- (60) Exi ena vivilo eki pera.
 have.3SG a.ACC book.ACC there over
 ‘There is a book over there.’
 (Kampanarou 2024:16-22).

Examples like (60) from Greek are plain violations of Burzio’s Generalization, but also pose a problem for any DC-approach to case which analyzes accusative case as a dependent case. Just as in Tagalog, the existential verb *exi* in Greek can occur with two arguments, the internal (Theme-)argument and another argument that semantically expresses a possessor.

- (61) I Maria exi amaksi.
 the.SG.NOM Mary.NOM have.3SG car.SG.ACC
 ‘Mary has a car.’
 (Kampanarou 2024:5)

A similar kind of paradigm arises with the ‘double accusative subject’ construction in Icelandic (Zaenan & Maling 1990, Schäfer 2008, Wood 2017, Haider 2019). In this construction, an intransitive subject may surface in the same accusative case as the corresponding object of a transitive. The examples below (from Schäfer 2008:291) illustrate.

- (62) a. Stormurinn rak batinn a land.
 the.storm.NOM drive the.boat.ACC on land
 ‘The storm drove the boat onto land.’
 b. Batinn rak a land.
 the.boat.ACC drove on land
 ‘The boat drifted onto land.’

Šereikaitė (2024) also describes what she refers to as the *active existential* in Lithuanian, a construction that contains an accusative marked theme (object) but lacks an overt (nominative) subject.

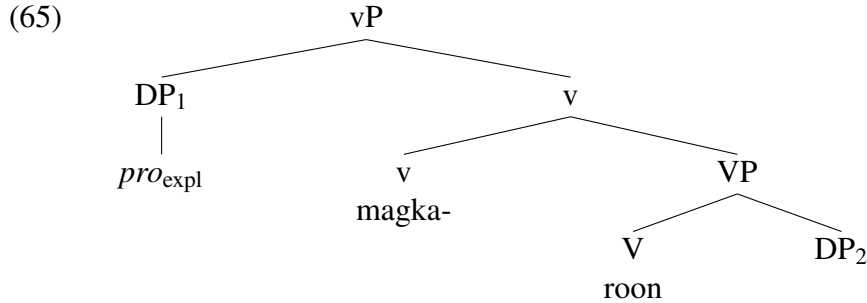
- (63) Vali-u kviči-a i dekana-a.
 Valius-ACC invite-PRS.3 to dean’s.office-ACC
 ‘Someone is inviting Valius to the dean’s office.’

As Šereikaitė (2024) notes, examples like this pose a problem for Burzio’s Generalization,

as well as theories of Dependent Case which treat the accusative case as a dependent case. Like the above cases, Šereikaitė does note that constructions like (63) have corresponding transitive alternates. Consider example (64).

- (64) (Tu) kviet-ei Marij-a i dekanat-a.
 you.NOM invite-PST.2SG Marija-ACC to dean's.office-ACC
 'You were inviting/invited Marija to the dean's office.'
 (Šereikaitė 2024:page)

Broadly speaking, there have been two approaches to the problematic intransitive constructions reviewed above. One approach, couched within an Agree-based theory of Case assignment, proposes that languages might have a v (v_{expl}) that assigns [Acc]-Case, but does not also introduce an external argument in the syntactic representation (see, e.g., Sigurdsson 2006, 2011, 2012; Šereikaitė 2022; Schäfer 2008). Alternatively, v_{expl} (or some such equivalent) does host a syntactically projected, but null, DP as its specifier (Wood 2017, Kampanarou 2024). If there is a syntactically projected DP, Wood and Kampanarou note, then availability of accusative-case (i.e., [Dep]-case) can be explained. Concretely, suppose that there is a syntactic projected DP in v P's specifier in the eventive existential in Tagalog, as represented in (65).



The null expletive in this structure can be considered a ‘competitor’ DP for case given the DC-approach. The algorithm in (43), in particular, will look at DP_1 and DP_2 and determine that DP_2 is the ‘optimal candidate’ for assignment of [Dep]-case, whereas DP_1 will be unmarked.

5.2. The Nature and Distribution of the Expletive

5.2.1 The Nature of the Expletive A reasonable concern to raise with the analysis involving a null expletive is that it involve positing a null *pro* for a language that is not otherwise a null argument (i.e., pro-drop) language. This issue is raised and discussed at length by Collins (2024) who very convincingly (in my mind) argues for the projection of an implicit *pro* in short passives in English, a language which, like Tagalog, is not otherwise a null argument language. In Collins’ theory, UG makes three types of implicit arguments available: a generic implicit argument (pro_{gen}); an existential implicit argument (pro_{un}); and a definite implicit argument (pro_{def}). If the null expletive proposed for Tagalog corresponds to any of these, it would be the existential pro_{un} , which has the following properties according

to Collins (see his work for elaboration of the content of the other two types of implicit arguments).

- (66) Pro_{un} (Collins 2024:20-23, 36):
- a. is a DP
 - b. lacks ϕ -features
 - c. is of type $\langle e \rangle$ and is bound by an existential operator.

For Collins, pro_{un} is a projected external argument in (short) passive sentences like (67), and therefore functions as the (implicit) agent of the verb.

- (67) John was killed.
- a. **Structure:** $[_{VP} pro_{un} [_{V'} V [_{VP} \text{killed John}]]]$
 - b. **Interpretation:** Someone killed John.

Plainly, the pro_{exp} that I have proposed for the eventive existential in Tagalog is not to be interpreted exactly as the implicit argument that Collins proposes for short passives like (67) – i.e., as an agent. As I see it, therefore are two other possibilities to consider regarding the nature of pro_{exp} . The first possibility is that pro_{exp} is, in fact, akin to Collins’ pro_{un} . In particular, it is an implicit argument assigned or associated with a θ -role. The θ -role in question might be an implicit version of the overt DP in (69) which denotes, broadly, a possessor. Under this view, pro_{exp} might be interpreted as something like “the world” or “the contextually relevant institution”, or just “people (in general)”, to name a few possibilities. Thus, for an example like (58c), pro_{exp} might be construed as something like “the institution of laws has protections against discrimination in the workplace”, (58b) might be construed as something like “the body has reasons for increasing blood pressure”, and so on.

Another possibility to consider is that the null expletive is a implicit locative, along the lines suggested for unaccusative predicates in Lasnik (2015). According to this approach, a simple sentence containing an unaccusative predicate like (68) can be represented semantically as containing an implicit location that is bound by an existential operator.

- (68) John arrived.
 $\exists l. \text{ arrived } (j, l)$

The broader idea being considered here is that the proposed expletive might have some basic semantic content, and as such – is only an expletive as far as its phonology is concerned. Given that the same predicate (*magkaroon*) may also appear with an overt DP argument as in the examples in (59), suggests that there is a relationship between these examples and those in (58) which lack the overt DP. The proposal here is that this relationship is in part explicable by positing the null expletive pronoun, which functions similarly to an implicit argument of the type (pro_{un}) proposed by Collins. If there is merit to these considerations, note that they offer independent support for proposing the expletive, i.e., independent of how positing this expletive solves the problem of [Dep]-case in examples like (58) according to the DC-approach in the absence of a competitor DP.

5.2.2. *The Distribution of the Expletive* A question relating to the proposal of the null expletive naturally arises concerning its distribution. We certainly do not want the expletive to be able to appear anywhere. Above, I suggested that the null expletive could take the place of an external argument, but this would have to be limited to predicates like the existential predicate (*magkaroon*), otherwise, we might expect ordinary transitive verbs to alternate with intransitives with a [Dep]-marked theme (i.e., analogous to the double accusative construction in Icelandic). This is not possible, however. Although certain predicates exhibit a transitive/intransitive alternation, the intransitive subject must surface in the [Unm]-case²³

- (69) a. N-agbasag si Juan ng salamin.
 AT.PERF-break UNM DEP mirror
 ‘Juan broke the mirror.’
 b. Bumagas ang/*ng salamin.
 AT.PERF.break UNM/DEP mirror
 ‘The mirror broke.’

The imposition of lexical restriction on predicates that do, and predicates that do not allow the projection of a null expletive is at least partially anticipated by the researchers whose work is cited above, as well as work by Deal (2009) on the selection of expletives in English. I have little more to say at this point regarding how these lexical restrictions should be handled, except to say that in the present framework they would have to be encoded through a special ‘flavor’ of v/Voice.

Apart from the issue of restricting the null expletive to certain predicates, there is also a general question regarding its basic syntactic distribution. Here, Collins’ (2024) proposal concerning pro_{un} is instructive. According to Collins’, the distribution of his implicit null argument is restricted by the claim that the null argument lacks ϕ -features. As a consequence of this, null arguments cannot be the target or the operation of Agree. Under his assumptions, Case is valued/assigned by Agree. Since the null argument cannot be Agreed with, it also therefore cannot receive Case. The null argument must always reside in-situ (Spec, vP) in a position which, according to Collins, is not targeted by Agree. Although I do not necessarily share all of Collins’ assumptions (in particular, about Case and Agree), it is the case under my proposal that the null expletive in Tagalog always C-commands the existential predicate’s internal argument (=the EC ‘pivot’). In other words, to state the distribution in relation to the DC-approach that I have taken here, we can make the following conjecture regarding the distribution of pro_{exp} :

²³A possible exception to this claim involves the ‘recent perfective’, an aspect that verbs occur in in which there is not SUBJECT*.

- (i) Kababasag ng salamin.
 REC.PERF.broke DEP mirror
 ‘The mirror just broke.’

See Hsieh 20205 for some initial description.

(70) Pro_{exp} must be the unmarked DP for purposes of determining dependent case.

Given the algorithm for determining (dependent) case, this will block pro_{exp} from object positions, as well as a host of other positions (complement of preposition, etc.). In short, though assumptions differ, the distribution of my proposed pro_{exp} seem to be identical to those of the pro_{un} proposed by Collins. This, I believe, is a desirable outcome, given especially that overlap in function between the two null argument-types (suggesting that they may be one and the same).

6 Conclusion

This paper has offered a new analysis of two aspects of Tagalog morphosyntax: Case morphology on DPs, and agreement on verbs in verbal clauses. The analysis of the form was stated exclusively in terms of a DC-approach to (morphological) case. As such, it is compatible with the view (articulated by Matrantz 1991) that morphological case bears no connection with Case, viewed as a syntactic licensing mechanism (for which there might be reason to eliminate completely from the Grammar). The latter was developed according to the view that agreement in Tagalog targets θ -roles, or – rather – θ -features. With this general perspective in mind, I put forward a theory of this agreement drawing upon the formal (feature-based) approach to θ -roles developed by Reinhart.

In so doing, I hope to have offered a simple analysis of case and agreement in Tagalog that does not encounter many of the technical problems of implementation that previous analyses have. I have argued, specifically, against the idea that agreement in Tagalog targets Case-features. I showed that approach such as Rackowski’s involving *Case-agreement* are difficult to formally express if the relevant heads (=probes) that assign/value Case also require this feature to be assigned/valued on itself. I tentatively suggested that Agree does not operate like this, in a manner where a probe is both responsible for valuing a feature, F, and (simultaneously) needing a value for this same feature. If my argument against Case-agreement is on the right track, such instances of Agree might not exist because they render probes inactive or unmotivated for Agree before they are able to complete their (full) mission.

With the proposal spelled out, I think moved on to consider the potentially problematic case of the eventive existential construction, which appeared to be an exceptional case that cannot be handled given the DC-approach. Drawing on related cases and proposals for other languages, I proposed that the eventive existential construction might contain a null expletive (pro_{exp} or perhaps, Collins’ pro_{un}). If this analysis proves tenable in the long run, this opens up the possibility of an avenue of research into the content and distribution of null expletives more generally, and to a (slight) reconsideration of what is entailed by being a null subject language compared to an overt subject language (given that, for instance, null expletives were typically held to exist only in the former type of language).

Finally, a remark concerning the work by Reinhart, whose θ -system heavily inspired

the θ -agreement analysis proposed in Section 4.2. In that work (see, for instance, Reinhart 2016: Chapter 1), Reinhart puts forward a rather bold hypothesis: That all intransitive predicates (in particular, unaccusatives) begin as di-transitive, but become unaccusative through a process she refers to as **Reduction**, which eliminates the external argument of the predicate, or **Saturation**, which involves an existential closing off of the external argument). While I do not formally adopt this assumption, it should be noted that the analysis of eventive existential that I have proposed is not far off base from Reinhart's proposal (nor, for that matter, are approaches such as the one taken by Kampanarou 2024 or Wood 2017). Specifically, instead of Reduction or Saturation, the di-transitive nature of the (eventive) existential is represented as a projected (indefinite) implicit argument.

References

- Aldridge, Edith. 2002. Nominialization and *wh*-movement in Seedqi and Tagalog. *Language and Linguistics* 5. 51-62.
- Aldridge, Edith. 2004. *Ergativity and word order in Austronesian languages*. Ithica, NY. PhD Dissertation, Cornell University.
- Aldridge, Edith. 2009. Minimalist questions for the nominalist analysis of Tagalog syntax. *Theoretical Linguistics* 35(1). 51-62.
- Baker, Mark C. & Nadya Vinokurova. 2010. Two modalities of Case assignment: Case in Sakha. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory*, 28:593-642.
- Baker, Mark C. & Jonathan Bobaljik. 2017. On inherent and dependent theories of case. In *Handbook of Ergativity*, edited by Jessica Coon, Diane Massam, and Lisa Travis.
- Baker, Mark C. 2014. On dependent ergative case (in Shipibo) and its derivation by phase. *Linguistic Inquiry* 45: 341-380.
- Baker, Mark C. 2015. *Case: Its Principles and Parameters*. Cambridge University Press.
- Baker, Mark. 2017. Ergative case in Burushaski: A dependent case analysis. In J. Coon, D. Massam, and L. Travis (eds.) *The Oxford Handbook of Ergativity*, 759-781. New York: Oxford University Press.
- Barrie, Michael & Audrey Li. 2015. The Semantics of (Pseudo) Incorporation and Case. In *Syntax and Semantics*, 40: 159-188.
- Bejar, Susana. 2008. Conditions on Phi-Agree. In Harbour, Daniel, Adger, David & Bejar, Susana (eds.), *Phi-theory: Phi features across the interfaces*, 130-154. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Bobaljik, Jonathan. 2008. Where's ϕ ? Agreement as a post-syntactic operation. In Harbour, Daniel, Adger, David & Bejar, Susana (eds.), *Phi-theory: Phi features across the interfaces*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

- Bobaljik, Jonathan & Susie Wurmbrandt. 2012. Case in GB/Minimalism. In Malchov, Andrej L. & Andrew Spencer (eds.), *The Oxford Handbook of Case*, 44-58. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Brenan, Kenyon & Michael Y. Erlewine. to appear. Locality and minimal search. *The Cambridge Handbook of Minimalism*.
- Carrier-Duncan, J. 1985. Linking of Thematic Roles in Derivational Word Formation. *Linguistic Inquiry* 16: 1-34.
- Chen, Victoria & Bradley McDonnell. 2019. Western Austronesian voice. *Annual Review of Linguistics* 5: 173–195.
- Chomsky, Noam. 1981. *Lectures on Government and Binding*. Dordrecht: Foris Publishers.
- Chomsky, Noam. 2000. Minimalist Inquiries: The framework. In Roger Martin, David Michaels, and Juan Uriagereka, eds., *Step by Step: Essays on minimalist syntax in honor of Howard Lasnik*, 89-155. Cambridge, Mass.: MIT Press.
- Chomsky, Noam. 2001. Derivation by phase. In Michael Kenstowicz, ed., *Ken Hale: A life in language*, 1-52. Cambridge, Mass.: MIT Press
- Chen, Victoria. 2025. The syntax of Philippine-type alignment: Insights from case-marking. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory*. DOI: 10.1007/s11049-025-09655-7
- Chung, Sandra & William Ladusaw. 2001. *Restriction and Saturation*. Cambridge, MA. MIT Press.
- Clem, Emily & Amy Rose Deal. 2025. Dependent case by agree: Ergative in Shawi. *Linguistic Inquiry*, to appear.
- Collins, Chris. *Principles of Argument Structure: A Merge-Based Approach*. Cambridge, MA. MIT Press.
- Collins, James N. 2018. Defineitness determined by syntax. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory*, 37:1367-1420.
- De Guzman, Videa. P. 1978. *Syntactic Derivation of Tagalog Verbs*. Honolulu: The University Press of Hawaii.
- Deal, Amy Rose. 2009. The Origin and Content of Expletives: Evidence from “Selection”. *Syntax* 12: 285-323.
- Deal, Amy Rose. to appear. Current models of Agree. In Crippen, James & Dechaine, Rose-Marie & Keupdjil, Hermann (eds.) *Move and Agree: Towards a formal typology*. John Benjamins.
- Dowty, David. 1991. Thematic proto-roles and argument selection. *Language* 67:547-619.
- Foley, W. A. (2008). The Place of Philippine Languages in a Typology of Voice Systems. In Austin, P. K. and Musgrave, S., editors, *Voice and grammatical relations in Austronesian languages*, chapter 2, pages 22–44. CSLI Publications, Stanford, CA.

- Haider, Hubert. 2019. On expletive, semantically voice, and absent subjects. In Peter Herbeck, Bernhard Poll, and Anne C. Wolfgruber (eds.) 11-46. *Semantic and syntactic aspects of impersonality*. Hamburg: Helmut Buske Verlag (Topic volume 26 of Linguistische Berichte).
- Hale, Kenneth & Samuel J. Keyser. 2003. On argument structure and the lexical expression of argument structure. In *The View From Building 20: Essays in Honor of Sylvain Bromberger*. Cambridge, MA. MIT Press.
- Horvath, Julia & Tal Sioni. 2016. The thematic phase and the architecture of grammar. In Evaet, Martin, Marjelj Marijana, and Eric Reuland (eds), *Concepts, Syntax, and their Interface*. 129-174. Cambridge, MA. MIT Press
- Himmelman, Nikolaus P. 2005. The Austronesian languages of Asia and Madagascar: Typological characteristics. In *The Austronesian languages of Asia and Madagascar*, ed. by K. Alexander Adelaar and Nikolaus P. Himmelman, 110–181. London: Routledge.
- Hornstein, Norbert. 1999. Movement and control. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 30:69-96.
- Kampanarou, Anna. 2024. Relating BE and HAVE via transitivity. *Glossa* 9:1-43. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.16995/glossa.10202>
- Kroeger, Paul 1993. *Phrase Structure and Grammatical Relations in Tagalog*. Stanford: CSLI Publications.
- Kim, Jeong-Seuk. 1997. Focus movement and ellipsis in Korean and Japanese. In *Proceedings of the 5th Meeting of the Conferences of the Student Organization in Linguistics in Europe*, 169-182. Lleiden: SOLE.
- Landau, Idan. 2010. The explicit syntax of implicit arguments. *Linguistic Inquiry* 41:357-388.
- Lasnik, Howard. 1995. A note on pseduo-gapping. In *MIT Working Papers in Linguistics (MITWPL): Papers on minimalist syntax*, 243-265.
- Legatte, Julie Anne. 2008. Morphological and Abstract Case. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 39:1, 55-101.
- Legatte, Julie Anne. 2014. Types of ergativity. *Lingua* 148.
- Marelj, Marijana. 2002. Rules that regulate co-occurrence of feature clusters in the Theta System. *Theoretical Linguistics* 28:257-375.
- Marantz, Alec. 1991. Case and licensing. In Westphal, German, & Ao, Benjamin & Che, Hee-Rahk (eds.), *Proceedings of the 8th Easter Conferences on Linguistics (ESCOL 8)*, 234-253. Ithica, NY: CLC Publications
- Marelj, Marijana. 2016. Theta Meets Case: An Externion. In Evaet, Martin, Marjelj Marijana, and Eric Reuland (eds), *Concepts, Syntax, and their Interface*. 113-128. Cambridge, MA. MIT Press

Rules that regulate co-occurrence of feature clusters in the Theta System. *Theoretical Linguistics* 28:257-375.

Massam, Diane. 2001. Pseudo Noun Incorporation in Niuean. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory*, 19:153-197

McFadden, Thomas. 2004. *The position of morphological case in the derivation: A study on the syntax-morphology interface*. Philadelphia, PA. PhD Dissertation (University of Pennsylvania)

Moltmann, Frederike. 2006. Generic *one*, Arbitrary PRO, and the First Person. *Natural Language Semantics* 14:257-281.

Nevins, Andrew Ira. 2004. Derivations without the activity condition. In McGinnis, Martha & Norvin Richards (eds), *Perspectives on phases*, Cambridge, MA. MIT Working Papers in Linguistics (MITWPL) 49.

Paul, Ileana, Key Cortes, & Lareina Milambiling. 2015. Definiteness without D: The case of Tagalog *ang* and *ng*. *Canadian Journal of Linguistics* 60:361-390.

Pearson, Matthew. The Malagasy subject/topic as an A'-element. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory* 23:381-457

Poole, Ethan. 2024. Dependent-case assignment could be Agree. *Glossa* 8:1, 1-23.

Preminger, Omer. 2014. *Agreement and its Failures*. MIT Press, Cambridge, MA.

Rackowski, Andrea. 2002. *The Structure of Tagalog: Specificity, Voice, and the Distribution of Arguments*. PhD Dissertation, MIT. Cambridge, MA.

Rackowski, Andrea & Norvin Richards. 2005. Phase edge and extraction: A Tagalog case study. *Linguistic Inquiry* 36:565-599.

Ramos, T. V. 1974. *The Case System of Tagalog Verbs*. Canberra: Dept. of Linguistics, Research School of Pacific Studies, Australian National University.

Reinhardt, Tanya. 2002. The Theta-System: An Overview. *Theoretical Linguistics* 28:229-290.

Reinhardt, Tanya. 2016. *Concepts, Syntax, and Their Interface: The Theta System*. Cambridge, MA. MIT Press.

Riesberg, Sonja & Beatrice Primus. 2015. Agent prominence in symmetrical voice languages. *Language Typology and Universals* 68:pages. DOI: 10.1515/stuf-2015-0023

Rizzi, Luigi. 1986. Null objects in Italian and the theory of *pro*. *Linguistic Inquiry* 17:501-557.

Sabbagh, Joseph. 2000. Existential sentences in Tagalog. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory* 27:675-719

Sabbagh, Joseph. 2016. Specificity and objecthood in Tagalog. *Journal of Linguistics* 52:639-688.

Schachter, Paul & Fe T. Otanes (1972). *Tagalog Reference Grammar*. Berkeley, University of California Press.

Schäfer, Florian. 2008. *The syntax of (anti-)causatives. External arguments in change-of-state contexts*. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.

Šereikaitė, Miliena. 2021. The active existential in Lithuanian: Remarks on Burzio's Generalization. *Linguistic Inquiry* 52:747-789.

Schütze, Carson. 2001. On the nature of default case. *Syntax* 4:205-238.

Woolford, Elen. 1997. Four way case systems: Ergative, nominative, objective, and accusative. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory* 15:181-227

Woolford, Elen. 2006. Lexical case, inherent case, and argument structure. *Linguistic Inquiry* 37:111-130.

Four way case systems: Ergative, nominative, objective, and accusative. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory* 15:181-227

Wood, Jim. 2017. The Accusative Subject Generalization. *Syntax*, 20: 249–291. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1111/synt.12138>